

Stigler's law of eponymy: Stigler (2002).

French book statistics: *Lire*, April 2005.

Why dispersion matters: More technically, the distribution of the extremum (i.e., the maximum or minimum) of a random variable depends more on the variance of the process than on its mean. Someone whose weight tends to fluctuate a lot is more likely to show you a picture of himself very thin than someone else whose weight is on average lower but remains constant. The mean (read skills) sometimes plays a very, very small role.

Fossil record: I thank the reader Frederick Colbourne for his comments on this subject. The literature calls it the “pull of the recent,” but has difficulty estimating the effects, owing to disagreements. See Jablonski et al. (2003).

Undiscovered public knowledge: Here is another manifestation of silent evidence: you can actually do lab work sitting in an armchair, just by linking bits and pieces of research by people who labor apart from one another and miss on connections. Using bibliographic analysis, it is possible to find links between published information that had not been known previously by researchers. I “discovered” the vindication of the armchair in Fuller (2005). For other interesting discoveries, see Spasser (1997) and Swanson (1986a, 1986b, 1987).

Crime: The definition of economic “crime” is something that comes in hindsight. Regulations, once enacted, do not run retrospectively, so many activities causing excess are never sanctioned (e.g., bribery).

Bastiat: See Bastiat (1862–1864).

Casanova: I thank the reader Milo Jones for pointing out to me the exact number of volumes. See Masters (1969).

Reference point problem: Taking into account background information requires a form of thinking in *conditional* terms that, oddly, many scientists (especially the better ones) are incapable of handling. The difference between the two odds is called, simply, conditional probability. We are computing the probability of surviving *conditional* on our being in the sample itself. Simply put, you cannot compute probabilities if your survival is part of the condition of the realization of the process.

Plagues: See McNeill (1976).